Why Moving Lead Sites Don't Work (And What Does)

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Every moving company owner has a story about lead platforms. It usually ends the same way: "I spent $2,000, got a bunch of calls, closed almost nothing, and eventually stopped."

This isn't bad luck. It's a structural problem with how these platforms work — and understanding it helps you stop wasting money and start investing in channels that actually convert.

The Structural Problem With Shared Moving Leads

When someone submits a move request on HireAHelper, Moving.com, moveBuddha, Thumbtack, or similar platforms, their information is immediately sold to multiple moving companies. Standard practice is 3 to 5 companies simultaneously.

The moment that lead arrives in your inbox, it's already in 3 other inboxes. The customer gets called by 4 movers in the next 15 minutes, gets 4 different quotes, and books whoever they found most responsive, most trustworthy, or cheapest.

Your close rate on shared leads — even with excellent follow-up and competitive pricing — typically runs 10 to 18%. That means 82 to 90% of what you pay for generates zero revenue.

The 2026 Math

Shared lead platform pricing has increased substantially:

Platform Type	Cost Per Lead	Close Rate	Cost Per Acquired Job
Standard shared lead	\$35 – \$75	12 – 18%	\$194 – \$625
"Exclusive" leads (often still shared)	\$70 – \$150	20 – 30%	\$233 – \$750

On a \$750 average job, spending \$300 to \$600 to acquire it leaves \$150 to \$450 in gross revenue before labor, fuel, insurance, and truck costs. In most cases, you're running at a loss or marginal profitability on platform-acquired jobs.

And yet the platforms keep the business model alive by creating the illusion of activity. Lots of leads coming in feels like marketing is working. Tracking the actual cost per acquired job reveals the reality.

What Actually Works for Moving Company Customer Acquisition

Google Business Profile (The Foundation)

Your Google Business Profile is the single highest-ROI marketing asset for a local moving company. It's free and it shows you on Google Maps when customers search "movers near me."

What makes it work: reviews. An operator with 50 reviews averaging 4.7 stars gets clicked dramatically more often than one with 8 reviews at 4.2. Reviews are the conversion rate optimization for local search.

Build your review base systematically. After every completed move, text the customer a direct link to your Google review page within 24 hours. At 15% conversion, 20 jobs per month generates 3 new reviews per month. Over 12 months: 36+ reviews.

Google Ads (For Exclusive Intent)

When someone searches "moving company [your city]" on Google, they're ready to hire. Google Ads puts you in front of that intent immediately — and your ad leads to your page only, not shared.

In smaller and mid-size markets where CPCs run $8 to $20, this channel delivers cost-effective exclusive leads. Major metros require more investment and optimization.

Pay-Per-Move

Zero upfront cost. Success fee only when a move completes. In an industry where lead platform economics are increasingly broken, this model makes more and more sense.

Your marketing partner's revenue depends on your jobs completing — which aligns their incentive with yours completely.

Corporate and Realtor Relationships

The highest-quality, lowest-cost leads in the moving industry come from realtors and corporate HR departments. A single realtor who closes 3 homes per month and refers their clients to you can send 6 to 12 moves per year with zero marketing cost after the relationship is established.

Call 10 local realtors this week. Most are not currently happy with their moving company referrals — they send clients to whomever their clients find, and the results are often inconsistent. An operator who introduces themselves, demonstrates professionalism, and follows up reliably will get the referrals.

Making the Switch From Lead Platforms

1. Calculate your actual cost per acquired job on platforms right now (lead cost ÷ close rate)

2. Compare it to your revenue per job
3. Decide how much margin you're actually making on platform-acquired jobs
4. If the answer is "very little" or "negative," stop spending there
5. Redirect that budget to Google Ads or pay-per-move

The transition takes 60 to 90 days to feel fully, as new channels ramp up. But operators who make the switch almost universally report better job quality, better close rates, and better margins from exclusive or success-fee channels.

Want to see what the economics look like in your market? Book a free strategy call.